

Chapter 88-4

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Liang Shi was still lost in amazement at how well Xu Qingzhu could play the cello.

But on the way back, Xu Qingzhu actually had her pull the car over to the side of the road and went to a supermarket to get a bunch of coins.

Liang Shi: "..."

After returning home, Liang Shi stood in the living room and asked her, "Are we really testing this?"

"I said we'd try when we got home," Xu Qingzhu said. "I've already gotten the coins."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi pulled her off-shoulder dress all the way down, turning it into a strapless dress, fully exposing her collarbone.

Xu Qingzhu called out to her, "Bend over."

Liang Shi bent over. Xu Qingzhu placed coins on her collarbone. After placing three, there was still space. Liang Shi was waiting for her to place the fourth one when, completely without warning, Xu Qingzhu bit down on Liang Shi's collarbone.

Just like Liang Shi had done at the beach that day—the motion was gentle, teeth lightly grazing across her skin, biting slowly and tenderly.

Her lips fell on Liang Shi's skin, softly kissing and sucking.

A moment later, Xu Qingzhu pulled away, casually collecting the three coins. Her voice was the same as usual. "Test complete."

If you listened carefully, you could hear the slight tremor in the tail of her voice, her breathing unsteady.

Xu Qingzhu shook the coins in her palm, producing a crisp clinking sound.

Liang Shi looked completely dazed.

Xu Qingzhu said, "Returning the favor."

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The day of the boot ceremony¹ was bright and sunny—rare good weather for late autumn in Haizhou City.

The location was in the suburbs of Haizhou City. Liang Shi packed her luggage simply and drove to the destination in high spirits.

She had experienced many boot ceremonies before, but this one was special.

This was the first boot ceremony she had attended since coming to this world.

Aside from the temporary role she had helped with last time, her first role was an impressive Female Lead #3²—quite a high starting point in the entertainment industry.

Because the boot ceremony was scheduled for 9 AM and it took over an hour to drive from home to the destination, plus she needed to get her hair and makeup done after arriving, Liang Shi left early. On the way, she received a message from Xu Qingzhu: 【You left?】

Liang Shi replied concisely: 【Mm-hmm.】

Xu Qingzhu quickly sent back: 【Wishing Teacher Liang a successful start! o/】

Followed by a very cute emoticon.

Liang Shi was driving, so she sent her a voice message: "Message received. Thank you, Teacher Xu."

Xu Qingzhu had probably just woken up. Her cool voice carried a hint of laziness, still a bit nasally, sounding soft and adorable. "Focus on driving."

Liang Shi felt like a feather had tickled her heart. The corners of her mouth unconsciously curved upward. "Got it. I made you breakfast. Remember to eat before going to work."

"Mm." The voice messages Xu Qingzhu sent were all very short. After saying "mm," she seemed to think for a moment. It also sounded like she hadn't fully woken up. After a pause, she said, "Act well. Don't embarrass yourself."

Liang Shi: "..."

She sent a meme.

Xu Qingzhu didn't reply again.

Sunlight spilled onto her car. She cracked the window open slightly, and the not-too-cold autumn breeze blew in, making her hair dance.

After Liang Shi arrived at the set, a staff member led her to the dressing room. On the way, she received a phone call from Gu Xingyue.

Gu Xingyue's voice on the phone was so despairing it had lost all vitality, yet it was calm and cold. "Can you help arrange for me to meet Gu Zhaoyuan?"

—"I'm willing to make a deal with you."

Liang Shi hadn't expected to receive a call from Gu Xingyue at this time.

The set was bustling with people coming and going, the noise almost drowning out Gu Xingyue's voice on the other end. Liang Shi followed the staff member while covering one ear with her hand, asking, "What did you say?"

"I said." Gu Xingyue took a deep breath on the other end, as if mustering all her courage, and repeated, "I'm willing to make a deal with you."

Liang Shi suddenly stopped in her tracks. She asked nervously, "Where are you?"

Through the phone, Liang Shi could hear the howling wind.

The wind was very strong. Combined with Gu Xingyue's voice, it sounded like it had been crumpled up and thrown into the wind, ready to be scattered to pieces if you weren't careful.

Liang Shi immediately thought of a rooftop, but Gu Xingyue said, "Don't worry. I won't kill myself. Help me arrange a meeting with Gu Zhaoyuan, and I'll give you everything you want."

Liang Shi finally felt relieved. "That's good then. Don't act impulsively. I'll help you contact Gu Zhaoyuan and keep it away from Yang Jiani. Live well, okay?"

"Mm." Gu Xingyue's voice was very cold, completely at odds with her previously gentle image. "The bad people haven't died yet. I won't die."

Liang Shi felt there was more to her words, but there was no time to ask in detail. The staff was still urging her. She could only give a few quick instructions, then promised to call her once everything was arranged.

Gu Xingyue hung up directly after hearing this.

Liang Shi stared at her phone, feeling that Gu Xingyue must have gone through something.

Could it be that Yang Jiani had hit her again?

Liang Shi was currently in the suburbs and couldn't get back anytime soon. Just worrying wasn't helpful—she could only deal with the matters at hand first.

The staff called her to get her hair and makeup done. Liang Shi acknowledged and hurried inside. Suddenly, her foot caught on something. In that instant, her gaze inadvertently swept to the side, and she saw a familiar figure.

The person was wearing a Klein blue T-shirt paired with high-waisted jeans, long hair casually tied in a ponytail, with a pure and cute face.

Liang Shi would never forget that face in her entire life.

It was—Sun Chengcheng!

Footnotes:

¹ **Boot ceremony (開機宴, kāi jī yàn):** A traditional ceremony held in the Chinese entertainment industry to mark the official start of filming for a TV drama or movie. It typically involves rituals for good luck, offerings to deities, and a gathering of the cast and crew. "開機" literally means "turning on the machine" (i.e., the camera), signifying the beginning of production.

² **Female Lead #3 (女三號, nǚ sān hào):** In Chinese drama terminology, characters are numbered by importance. Female Lead #1 (女一號) is the main female protagonist, Female Lead #2 (女二號) is the second most important female role, and Female Lead #3 (女三號) is the third. Despite being third, this is still considered a significant supporting role with substantial screen time.